

5-Alpha-Reductase Inhibitors (Prostate-Shrinking Pills)

Patient Information · Pills that slowly shrink an enlarged prostate

WARWIKI

These medicines **slowly shrink an enlarged prostate (BPH)**. Over time they improve urine flow and lower the chance of being unable to urinate or needing prostate surgery. The two used for BPH are **finasteride (Proscar)** and **dutasteride (Avodart)**. They work slowly, so give them several months.

How It Works

These pills stop the body from turning testosterone into **DHT**, the hormone that makes the prostate grow. With less DHT, the prostate **slowly shrinks** and the urine channel opens up. The benefit builds over **3–6 months**, so they are not a quick fix. They are often paired with a faster-acting alpha blocker.

Benefits and Risks in Numbers

In a 4-year study of finasteride in men with a large prostate:

5 in 100

needed prostate surgery, compared with 10 in 100 on a sugar pill

3 in 100

became unable to urinate, compared with 7 in 100 on a sugar pill

8 in 100

had erection problems in the first year, compared with 4 in 100 on a sugar pill

Numbers are averages from published studies. Your own risk may differ; ask your team.

What to Expect

- Best for **larger** prostates. Your team will usually check how it is working within about 6 months.
- Taken **once a day**, with or without food, for as long as it helps.
- If you stop, the prostate can grow back within a few months.

Learn the Terms

5-ARI

Short for 5-alpha-reductase inhibitor, such as finasteride or dutasteride.

BPH

Benign prostatic hyperplasia. An enlarged prostate that is not cancer.

DHT

The hormone that makes the prostate grow. These pills lower it.

PSA

A prostate blood test. These pills lower the number by about half.

Urinary retention

Being unable to empty the bladder. These pills lower the risk over time.

It changes your PSA test. These pills lower your **PSA by about half**. This does not harm you, but it changes how the test is read. Make sure everyone who checks your PSA knows you take one. Any rise in your PSA while you take the pill needs to be checked, even if the number looks normal.

How to Take It

- Take it **once a day**. Swallow dutasteride capsules whole; do not open or chew them.
- Do not stop just because you feel no change in the first months.

Important Safety

- **Anyone who is or may be pregnant** should not handle crushed or broken finasteride tablets or **any** dutasteride capsules. It can harm a male baby. If skin touches a broken tablet or a leaking capsule, wash right away with soap and water. Whole, coated finasteride tablets are safe to handle.
- **Do not donate blood** while taking these pills. After dutasteride, wait at least 6 months. Ask the blood service about finasteride.
- Tell your team about any **low mood or depression**, which has been reported.

Common Side Effects

- Lower sex drive, erection trouble, or less semen
- Breast tenderness or swelling
- New sexual side effects are most likely in the first year. Breast changes can still start later. A few men report sexual effects that last after stopping. Talk with your team about any concerns.

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- A **breast lump**, breast pain, or fluid from the nipple
- New low mood or depression

Go to an emergency department if:

- You have thoughts of harming yourself
- You cannot urinate and your bladder feels full or painful
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. These pills shrink the prostate slowly. Give them 3–6 months.
2. They cut your PSA about in half. Tell anyone who checks it.
3. Anyone who may be pregnant should not handle broken finasteride tablets or dutasteride capsules.